back and forth in unison, setting up a dangerous wave pattern that sent all the traders toppling to the floor, some of them continuing to buy and sell as they went down.

The agricultural pits—live hogs and cattle, corn and soybeans—were populated with middle-aged men and women who could have been the parents of the traders in the financial pits. Many stood around reading their newspapers and seemed to lack for things to do. The foreign-currency pits lay somewhere between bonds and agriculture in general mayhem and in the age of the participants.

Around the circumference of the crowded pits, a ring of bodies faced the wrong way—that is, with their backs to the action. These people seemed to signal in a forward direction, then turned back to peek into the pits. A tour guide told me they were messengers who communicated between the pits and the trading desks, which could be identified by huge vertical placards that said LIND-WALDOCK, PRUDENTIAL-BACHE, MERRILL LYNCH, HEINHOLD COMMODITIES, among others. Between their peeking and gesturing, the messengers launched handwritten notes that sailed like frisbees and magically landed on the proper desks, 10 to 15 yards away.

I left the visitor's galleries to revisit Mr. Epstein and to report on what I'd seen. He gave me an overview of the caste system on the floor: at the lowest level, the messengers, many of them college dropouts, who were paid a modest salary for signaling and card-flipping, hoping someday to move into the pits; at the next level, the recorders and inspectors, salaried employees of the exchanges; then finally the traders, divided into various categories of risk and reward. The most conservative were floor brokers, who bought and sold for outside clients and lived off their commissions. Next were scalpers, who took small risks, buying and selling futures for quick profits. Then came the day traders, who took longer and riskier positions but were out of the market at the end of each day. Then there were position players, who rode favorable trends for weeks or even months. On top of that, there were spreaders and straddlers, who hedged their bets from one pit to another, moving between futures and options just as Mr. Gressel had done in New York.

"Ultimately," said Mr. Epstein, "it's a zero-sum game. Somebody wins a dollar, somebody else must lose a dollar." With all